

A New Nature?

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Abstract— John Dixon Hunt, a Landscape Historian, theorizes nature into three distinct categories: The first, wilderness (untouched by man). The second, agricultural and urban development of towns and cities. The third, aesthetically appealing gardens and parks. The relationship between the natures alter through the ages. Before mankind our planet was covered with wilderness of the first nature, as man evolved and began to cultivate crops and build permanent settlements, the second nature began to surface. When settlements turned into civilizations and people changed their landscapes to suit what they found aesthetically appealing, is when the third nature was born. As civilizations grew into empires and empires into countries, the collaboration between the three natures transformed with time.

Today the three natures may exist at a distorted scale altogether, with the third nature seen as small gardens within the city's framework, the second nature seen as vast agricultural land on the outskirts, and the first nature almost extinct. However, the 21st century man is noticing that the increased disproportion and distance between the three natures is proving unsuitable for an assured future. Hence, with the advancement of research and new technologies, the landscaped spaces we are beginning to create focus on reconstructing and reforming the planet so that it isn't overtaken by climate change, extinction and degradation. Theorists today believe that our focus has shifted from the 'three natures' seen in beautiful decorative villa gardens of rich merchants and sacred groves for the Gods to a new nature- The Fourth Nature identifying as a futuristic synchronization of the three natures.

The Fourth Nature is seen as regenerative natural systems where Landscape architects, ecologists, engineers, horticulturists, biologists etc. collaborate to understand the ecological network of regions and find solutions to bring about the best possible changes to create a balanced ecosystem where a rich web of species including humans thrive. Yet, if one may look back at landscapes of the past all over the world, they were designed to complement the creations of God. The sacred groves in the Acropolises or the engineered forested terraces seen in the paintings of the Hanging Gardens of Babylon or even the sacred forests for the Gurukuls mentioned in ancient Indian scriptures were depicted as natural systems designed by man for ecosystems to thrive in, and man was part of the system, not above it. So what really is the Identity of future landscapes? Is it a rescaled technologically advanced reflection of past methods? Or is it a new system altogether, a fourth nature where the process and intent of design is devoid of the traditions and wisdom of the past?

Keywords—Nature, Culture, Science, Theory of three natures, Framework, 4th Nature, Identity.

I. INTRODUCTION

Our planet is a plethora of geological and hydrological features made up of materials and processes that synchronize together to form perfect habitats for a variety of flora and fauna. The geography blends from one feature into another and continuously changes over time by internal and external forces. Flora and fauna are designed to adapt and evolve with these changes. To understand these changes flora and fauna developed instincts that would help them create patterns to

respond to these changes. Even the smallest of ants could understand the seasonal changes, developing habits to store food for the winter or lower storey plants in dense deciduous forests developed large leaves to capture as much sunlight as possible. Similar to these, our ancestors, the hunter gatherers developed an expert understanding of place. They made decisions such as where to settle, where to hunt and where to hide. They mastered the processes of nature such as seasonal changes and its impact on the surrounding landforms and water bodies and their extended impact on the lifecycles of the surrounding flora and fauna. This was the initial seed of learning the field of landscape architecture. Settlements developed as a result of these learnings. Identifying which plants to gather and which not, which soil types to cultivate crops on and when does it lose value, water cycles to build houses in a way to avoid floods but allow irrigation in the fields. These basics were the core **sciences** behind the development of early settlements of mankind. These patterns in nature gave rise to rituals. Man selected certain types of landscapes for worship and certain kinds of landscape for social cohesion and another for burying or cremating the dead. Every settlement created their own rules and habits around nature which gave rise to **culture**. The congregation of the three ie. Nature, Science and Culture became the foundation of the field of Landscape Architecture.

II. THEORY OF THREE NATURES

Landscape architecture has been theorized by several experts based on the type and degree of human intervention carried out on it. Such as John Dixon Hunt's Theory of Three Natures from his book '*In Garden Perfections: The Practice of Garden Theory*' (2000) divides nature very distinctly into three main categories:

- A. *First Nature*: wilderness, untouched by man, pure, it is also the raw material for the second nature
- B. *Second Nature*: Agriculture, Urban development, roadways. A requirement for man to create settlements, towns and cities. The second nature was created within the first nature and over time began to eat away into the first nature.
- C. *Third Nature*: Aesthetic landscapes, gardens. Gardens fell within the second nature as the cities and towns provided spaces for the existence of the third nature.

An illustration made by Abbe Pierre Le Lorraine de Vallemont (Fig.1) long before the theory was introduced, was Hunt's reference for his studies. The drawing was deciphered by dividing the illustration into 3 parts- In the background the forested mountains which are natural and untouched (first nature) rolls into an agricultural field - a necessity for man's livelihood and survival (second nature). And in the foreground is a formal garden made by man's perception of art, geometry and aesthetics (third nature). These three natures were evident throughout the history of landscape architecture all over the world. The earliest renditions of the third nature is seen documented in the first written manuscripts of Uruk, carved on

III. INTERACTION BETWEEN MAN AND NATURE

Landscape Architecture has evolved with time based on three major factors:

- A. *Nature*: Landscape Architecture is designed based on the environment around it, the climate, the types of vegetation that grows in that climate, the seasonal changes impacting the cycles of these plants and accordingly the types of faunal species attracted to it. Over time, due to the impact of human interference in the natural order, a drastic change is clearly visible in the adaptive nature of plants and animals. An increase in invasive weeds and species has taken place, shifting of ecosystem belts due to increase in global warming has been observed and even for commercial purposes, even the invention of hybrid plants has been introduced.
- B. *Culture*: Landscape architecture is always designed based on the latest trends of man at a given time. The culture of the time defined the purpose of the landscape, whether it was designed for the Gods or Kings in the past, or for the people and the environment today. Landscape layouts and its design features are defined by trending art, religious beliefs, philosophies or fashions of the time it is created in.
- C. *Science*: New engineering techniques and methods impacted man's control over all natural systems in many ways: Some for natural resources such as mining, some to create routes such as tunnels, bridges and reclamation, some to rejuvenate barren and destroyed land such as Bio-mining and large-scale earthworks, and some for farming methodologies to quicken and improve the harvesting and quality of the food produced. The more advanced the field of science gets, the more are the possibilities of man to alter and innovate landscape methods.



Fig 1- Frontispiece to l'Abbé de Vallemont's *Curiositez de la nature et de l'art* (1705)

the temple walls or in the hieroglyphical representation of a royal garden within the palace complexes of Egypt or in the description of Ashok-Vatika in the Ramayan or the poems about the Island gardens of the Han dynasty. When we look at these historical landscapes all the way from its depiction carved in stone to the beautifully preserved gardens of palaces, it is very evident that these landscapes at all scales were made for a singular purpose, whether it was for scholars to discuss science in such as the philosophical gardens of the Acropolis or for the kings and queens to impress and intimidate their foreign delegates with the vastness of their chateau gardens or the tomb gardens of the Mughals designed to symbolize verses of the Quran describing 'Jannat' (heaven).

Over time the purpose of designed landscapes began to change. The royal gardens and the temple gardens began opening themselves for the use of the public, at first on special occasions and over time for general use. Initially the only public spaces for the common-folk were market places, Piazzas, Forums, Bazaars or Maidans which were open multipurpose grounds used by the public for various events such as shopping, festivities or meetings. In 1847, England made its first Public Park-Birkenhead Park creating a landmark inspiring several other cities around the world to design public parks for the citizens and common people to use. These public gardens and parks began to hold multiple features and amenities to address the needs of the public. The concept of singular purpose landscapes began to weaken.

These 3 factors majorly impacted the methods and approach towards Landscape Architecture, allowing it to advance along with man's evolution. Today, Landscapes have moved towards a new culture, focusing on aspects like *transformation* such as the post industrial parks of rundown industrial and transport corridors in Europe and America, or *conservation* such as the restoration of Mughal and Rajput Gardens or *revival* such as the ecologically sensitive parks designed on former wastelands or quarries in Pune and Timba or *technology* like the super trees of Singapore. Landscape Architecture has developed into platforms for experts from a variety of fields such as ecology, anthropology, horticulture, engineering and many more to create spaces which are purposeful to man and the surrounding environment. So how do we categorize these complex spaces within Dixon's simple framework of three natures. His rigid categorizations make it impossible to decide the core purpose of the Landscaped spaces we see today.

Robert Thayer, a professor of UC Davis wrote a paper in 1994 about categorizing technology and landscape within three dimensions of human interaction with it. He designed a triangle (Fig.2) where each side is a dimension: Topophilia (love for nature, purely natural, designed for the land and water, vegetation and fauna eg. a wilderness trail), Technophilia (Designed for the purpose or with the help of technology eg. a wind-farm) and Technophobia (considered the negative of both the other categories where neither the use of technology or the use of flora or fauna were used to create the space eg. a toxic

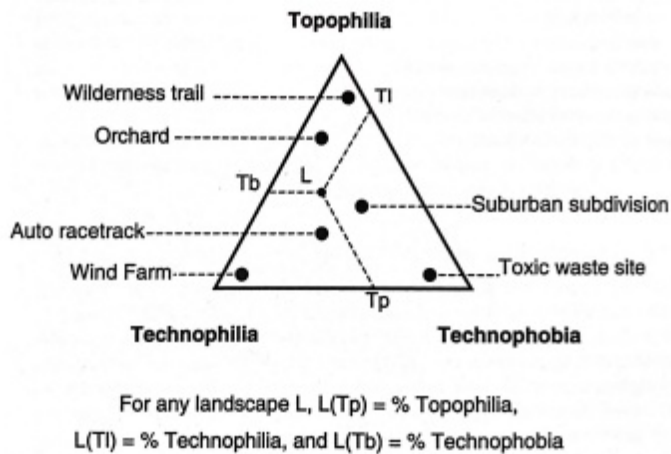


Fig 2 - Three attitudes towards landscape

wasteland). A landscape design could be located anywhere within the triangle based on its percentage of likeness to any of the three dimensions. This theory may not be 100% mathematically accurate, but it does allow us to understand that landscape architecture is too complex a field to be classified under one single identity of first, second or third natures. Does that give it a new meaning to its existence all together?

IV. A NEW NATURE?

Many theorists and landscape architects have considered giving today's landscape the identity of a 4th Nature, considering it to be much more than the romantic poetic landscape of the past, instead an answer to all the environmental issues that have been created: a solution to industrialization, overpopulation, deforestation, habitat loss and extinction. Today, Landscape Architecture has to bear the torch for moving towards a cleaner, greener and diverse future and not be designed as a symbol of God, Art or Power. It no longer is designed solely for man but for every living creature present in that space and the hydrological, geological or any other natural system linked to the space. But does this mean that it is completely unhinged from the landscapes of the past? Or is it merely the evolution of man's research and knowledge which has made him understand the crisis our planet is in today?

The status we give Landscape Architecture today- the epitome of Green and Sustainable is man's solution to his comprehension of our planet's crisis. Earlier our ancestors understood *geographical systems* to create settlements, or *God* to create sacred groves, or *politics and social status* to create chateau landscapes or *art* to create Renaissance villa gardens, similarly, a slightly more educated and culturally evolved man today has understood that he will not be able to survive with a deteriorating environment and his knowledge of newer technology and sciences, allows him to create a cultural trend in Landscape architecture that Rejuvenates, Restores and Remediate the spaces.

Current day landscapes, in pursuit of solving the environmental crisis as well as providing comfort, recreation and entertainment to man has produced multifunctional spaces that may not be identifiable under any one category of the three natures. But similar to Thayer's three dimensions of technological landscapes, they can be located within a three dimensional framework of the first, second and third nature, and its identity will be perceived by the amount of likeness the

space has to any of the three natures (Fig.3). For example, an Urban park today which would ideally hold value as a second nature may also have the poetic and aesthetic values of the third nature and may also contain a wilderness trail that may embody the values of the first nature. Different designs and spaces maybe located on different parts of the triangle based on the percentage of its affiliation to each nature, and with time the priority of one nature over the other may increase or decrease, but Landscapes will always be a blend of all three.

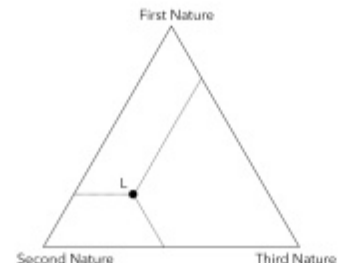


Fig 3 - Three Dimensions of the Three Natures

V. CONCLUSION

Landscape Architecture, in the past, present and future will be man's response to an understanding of his *surrounding environment*, the *cultural trend* and *newer technology* at a certain period of time. Man has designed landscapes prioritizing certain aspects over the other using Landscape architecture as a solution to warp the planet into his ideas of what is best for him. Today his priority is the deteriorating environment, tomorrow it may be something else. Hence over the past century, theorists have made numerous frameworks similar to that of Dixon's and Thayer's to manage and strategies landscape like any other design field. These theories are viewed as comprehension of past designs. However we as landscape architects should take them forward as tools to give a committed understanding of the processes of nature, society and technology used in the past and today. Only then will we be able to see where our designs stand within these frameworks and use it as motivation to reach beyond what has been done before and expand our boundaries towards creating spaces for the future.

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